Barkle-Week 7 Assignment 2: Iteration and Reflection
Project: MMHP Park Event Calendar

Part 1: Feedback Summary

The feedback I received came from two different sources: peer review and real-world user testing, and they revealed two very different types of issues.

Peer feedback focused primarily on usability and clarity. One reviewer noted that the navigation buttons “change order and switch around,” which created inconsistency. Another pointed out that the site needs to better explain itself, especially for older or less technical users. The common theme was that while the site works, it assumes too much from the user and does not clearly communicate its purpose.

The more valuable feedback came from local community users during beta testing. These users had little difficulty using the site itself. The biggest issue was not interacting with the site, but accessing it. Several users struggled to scan a QR code or understand how to bookmark the page on their phones. This was unexpected. The problem shifted from “how to use the site” to “how to use the device to access the site.”

Another unexpected issue came from using placeholder or inaccurate data. Test users focused heavily on incorrect or unrealistic events instead of evaluating the experience. This showed that unrealistic data creates confusion and distracts from usability testing.

Overall, the feedback confirmed that the system works, but highlighted gaps in clarity, access, and data realism.

Part 2: Iteration Decisions

The iteration process resulted in two distinct categories of changes: user-facing improvements and administrative improvements.

On the user-facing side, I stabilized the navigation layout after feedback showed that shifting button positions created confusion. This change was based on the principle that consistency reduces cognitive load. I also adjusted the structure of the site to make it more self-explanatory. Instead of adding instructions, I relied on layout and organization to communicate purpose, aligning with the original goal of creating a system that feels familiar and requires no learning curve.

At the same time, I made a deliberate decision to limit forward-facing feature expansion. The feedback did not indicate a need for more features, and adding complexity would conflict with the goal of simplicity. However, I did introduce a small number of targeted features that support the original design intent. For example, I added export functionality that allows users to download a list of events and print it. This reinforces the analog behavior the system is designed to mimic, such as posting a schedule on a refrigerator.

A second category of changes came from my own feedback during development. While the site was simple for users, it was becoming difficult to manage. To address this, I added administrative improvements, including export tools and a hidden access point that allows quick navigation to the Google Calendar input system. These changes are intentionally not visible to general users. The reasoning is that the public experience should remain simple, while the maintenance side can be more technical if it improves efficiency and reduces errors.

I also made a significant adjustment to how data is handled. Early versions of the site included placeholder or inaccurate data to simulate a full system. This created confusion during testing, as users focused on incorrect information rather than the experience. As a result, I cleaned the dataset and reduced unnecessary entries. Going forward, I will prioritize realistic data over volume to ensure feedback reflects actual usability.

Some changes are still planned before Project 02. These include refining the event-detail workflow and adding simple guidance for bookmarking the site on mobile devices. This directly addresses the access issue identified during beta testing.

Part 3: Evaluation Approach

The primary measure of success for this project is whether a resident can quickly find and understand an event. If a user can open the site, identify what is happening, and understand the details without confusion, the system is effective.

Beta testing provided the most meaningful evaluation. Users were able to navigate the site with minimal difficulty, which confirms that the core interface is working as intended. However, the testing also revealed that access to the site is a barrier. Based on this, success is not only defined by usability within the site, but also by how easily users can return to it. This has shifted part of the evaluation focus toward accessibility outside the interface, such as bookmarking and entry points.

Another evaluation criterion is alignment with the original design goals. The system is intended to reduce cognitive load, avoid unnecessary features, and present information in a familiar format. These goals are used as a benchmark for determining whether changes improve or degrade the system.

There are limitations to this evaluation. Testing was informal and limited to a small group of users. Feedback is qualitative rather than quantitative, and no formal usability metrics were collected. However, the feedback is directly tied to the target audience, which makes it more relevant than generalized testing.

Part 4: Process Reflection

The most important lesson from this process is that iteration is not about making a system more powerful. It is about making it more usable. Early in the project, I focused on building a functional system. Through feedback, I realized that functionality alone is not enough if the user does not immediately understand how to use it.

The hardest part of moving from Project 01 to Project 02 was managing the balance between simplicity and capability. There were multiple opportunities to add features or automate processes, but doing so would have made the system more complex without improving the user experience. At the same time, I had to address the fact that a system that is easy to use but difficult to manage will fail over time. This led to a separation between the user experience and the administrative tools, where each can be optimized independently.

Compared to the original proposal, the core idea of a simple, calendar-based system has remained unchanged. What has changed is the understanding of where complexity belongs. The public-facing system must remain simple, while the maintenance side can include more advanced tools if they improve reliability and efficiency.

If I were to start over, I would focus earlier on real user testing instead of relying on assumptions. The beta testing revealed issues that would not have been identified through design alone, particularly around how users access the system rather than how they use it.

This project brings together multiple areas of the CMPA program, including user-centered design, information organization, and front-end development. More importantly, it demonstrates how those skills are applied to solve a real problem. The final result is not defined by the number of features, but by how effectively it meets the needs of its users.